

OPEN: Design, Deception, and Emotional Systems Behind an Opened Door

Introduction: Concept and Inspirations

Open is a 2D pixel-art narrative game built in Unity 2022.3.56f1. The project originated from a simple but compelling idea: what if the player, assuming the role of a character named Minty, slowly realized that their identity was an illusion, and they were actually playing as Ed, a misunderstood and isolated boy accused of a terrible crime? This twist shaped the design and emotional direction of the entire game.

The story of Open begins with you playing as Minty, following her older brother Wally's orders to care for their youngest sibling, Ed, who is locked away at the house. The first scene the player will be in is the kitchen, and they first check for the notes that Wally left for Minty before he left for work early in the morning. In it, he tells her to stick to her usual routine of staying home and doing her summer reading, and, if necessary, heat up the left-over meal in the fridge and deliver it to Ed. This will encourage the player to navigate different rooms. For example, summer reading takes place in Minty's bedroom, checking the food happens in the kitchen, and delivering Ed's meal requires first going to Wally's room, where he mentioned the spare key is kept, and then to the room where Ed has been locked away.

As the player navigates different rooms, they begin to piece together the family's history. The house has been home to a fractured family for the past year. The father, a busy businessman, is absent most of the time, prioritizing his career over family life, especially after the mother's death. The mother died a year ago in a fire that consumed their previous home, leaving behind her three children. Everyone, including the family and the police, suspects that he was

responsible for the fire. For the sake of the family's reputation or perhaps as a form of misguided protection, Wally, the eldest son, hides Ed at home and forbids him from leaving. Ed tried to leave the house once to visit their mother's grave for the death anniversary, but Wally caught him, and after an argument, locked him in the basement to keep things under control. Wally now works at his father's company and has taken on the role of head of the household. Minty, the middle child, is a high school sophomore. And then there is Ed, the youngest, locked away from the outside world. From the various pieces of information scattered throughout the game, players can infer that the family members love each other and are trying to do what they think is right, especially Wally and Minty.

I drew initial inspiration from narrative-driven games like *The Witch's House* and *HOUSE*, both of which emphasize spatial exploration and storytelling through environmental cues. These games do not rely on cutscenes or overt exposition but instead immerse the player in their world through implication, misdirection, and subtle horror. *The Witch's House* uses space and objects to hint at hidden horrors, and its multiple endings gradually reveal a twist about the player's true identity. *HOUSE*, meanwhile, transforms an ordinary home into a site of dread with branching outcomes and a final boss confrontation. These influences led me to choose a 2D pixel art RPG format that privileges environmental storytelling, ambiguity, and emotional immersion through both agency and limitation.

Narrative and Thematic Structure

The story of *Open* revolves around a seemingly simple objective: as "Minty," the player is told to follow Wally's instructions to stay home, complete homework, and deliver food to Ed. However, as players explore the house and interact with their surroundings, they gradually

discover that they are not Minty at all, but Ed—who has already killed Minty when she came to deliver food. The player, like Ed, is subjected to control and restriction, gradually uncovering the traumatic events that led to their mother's death and Minty's own tragic fate.

This deception aligns with Nguyen's argument in *Games and the Art of Agency* that games can submerge the player in alternate agencies, leading them to pursue goals that change meaning over time. Nguyen introduces the concept of motivational inversion, where the player's original objectives are re-evaluated as the game progresses. In *Open*, the player begins with the goal of obedience and the Wally's rules, but eventually realizes that their true purpose is to uncover the past and reclaim agency.

This sense of shifting goals is further enhanced by the game's intentionally open structure. There is no enforcement mechanism requiring the player to complete tasks in a specific order, nor are there barriers that prevent room exploration until certain conditions are met. This design choice increases the player's sense of agency and mirrors a more natural, real-world simulation. Players are free to explore the house at their own pace, and in doing so, they might miss essential information or reach one of the endings without ever fully uncovering the truth. This lack of narrative enforcement reinforces the game's themes of misunderstanding and truth. Players may reach a premature conclusion, just as the family may have prematurely judged Ed, only to be motivated on a second or third playthrough to take a different path, investigate more deeply, and ultimately reshape their understanding of the story.

The presence of multiple endings also supports this interpretive replayability. Each ending presents a different perspective on the overarching narrative and is illustrated through animated sequences without dialogue or textual explanation. This lack of explicit resolution

invites players to form their own conclusions. For instance, in the Suicide Ending, triggered when the player chooses to use the kitchen knife on themselves, Ed sees a vision of his mother with her arms outstretched, as if offering a forgiving embrace. One interpretation might suggest that the mother knows the truth and absolves Ed of guilt. Another reading might be that she forgives him regardless of his role in the fire. A third possibility is that this vision is merely Ed's desperate fantasy for forgiveness, rather than a depiction of any afterlife encounter.

Another ending, triggered when the player kills Wally, presents a quiet and ambiguous image: a child sitting in a purple-themed bedroom that closely matches Ed's color palette, reading a book that resembles the inventory UI. The child is never explicitly identified during the gameplay, raising more questions. Is this Ed's child, born after he escaped and started a new life? Has the entire narrative been real, or is it a fictionalized account penned by Ed himself? The ambiguity of these scenes invites speculation, adding emotional and intellectual depth while encouraging players to pursue every ending. In this way, collecting all endings becomes not just a gameplay goal but a thematic reinforcement of the story's central conflict between perception and truth, punishment and forgiveness. This design also aligns with Jesper Juul's argument in *The Art of Failure* that failure, though unpleasant, deepens player engagement. In Open, players can miss key items, fail to piece together the full backstory, or reach an irreversible ending based on a single decision. These experiences are not mere setbacks. They mirror Ed's emotional reality of confusion, guilt, and isolation. By allowing endings to unfold without guaranteed clarity or resolution, the game encourages players to reflect on what they missed and try again. That very loop of failure and replay mirrors the haunting uncertainty that defines Ed's world and strengthens the emotional weight of the story's most ambiguous outcomes (Juul).

Technical Design: Systems and Interactions

The house in Open is constructed from interconnected scenes: Kitchen, Hallway, 2nd Floor, Basement, Dad's Room, Minty's Room, Ed's Room, Storage, and several endings such as Escape (multiple versions), Prison, and Suicide. Each room has specific triggers, dialogue events, and interactions.

Scene transitions are handled through the `SceneTransition.cs` and `EdRoomExitTrigger.cs` scripts. The game state is tracked using a singleton `GameStateManager.cs`, which remembers if Ed has discovered key memories, picked up objects, or killed Wally.

Players can interact with items and objects using a system of trigger colliders and scripts like `ItemPickup.cs`, `InteractableObject.cs`, and `InteractionIndicatorOpen.cs`. If a player picks up a knife or a family photo, the object is stored in a global inventory system handled by `InventoryManager.cs` and displayed through a dynamic `InventoryUIController.cs`. Each collectable object is implemented as a `ScriptableObject`. This allowed for clean modularity and easy assignment of descriptions, icons, and behavioral flags. Items persist between scenes and can only be used once in the final confrontation with Wally. The player can hold an item by pressing H and use it with U, with in-world emotes appearing above Wally or Ed to indicate potential use.

Managing data persistence across scenes, especially with multiple conditional endings, presented a significant design challenge. Each ending required checks for different combinations of game state variables, such as whether Ed had discovered his memories, whether Wally was killed, or which item was used in the final scene. Without a centralized system, this could have quickly become unmanageable. The early decision to implement a singleton script helped maintain consistent logic throughout scene transitions and ensured that conditions could be

tracked globally. Similarly, the use of ScriptableObjects for items, like the knife, food plate, and family photo, makes it easier to assign unique behaviors to each item while avoiding hardcoded values spread across multiple scripts. As a result, the game was able to maintain narrative and mechanical consistency across its branching paths and multiple scene changes.

Environmental Storytelling

Clune's *Gamelife* influenced my decision to use a structured 2D environment rather than a 3D space. Clune argues that 2D maps give players a broader awareness and more critical engagement with their surroundings, allowing them to track subtle narrative clues. In *Open*, the top-down clarity of the house layout ensures that players are constantly aware of spatial relationships which is crucial when piecing together the fractured family history (Clune).

The camera switches to following the player instead of providing a bird's-eye perspective like the rest of the scenes in the game in the Ed's Room scene, where Minty's body is placed. This is to create a more intimate and disorienting effect, aligning the player's field of view with Ed's emotional state. By removing the broader spatial awareness normally granted through the top-down layout, the game visually signals a shift in narrative tone—moving from external exploration to internal confrontation. The tighter camera framing enhances the claustrophobic atmosphere and forces the player to focus on the moment of realization, emphasizing the gravity of what Ed has done. This choice not only heightens emotional immersion but also reinforces the narrative twist, as the physical space narrows just as the player's perception of the story does.

Jagoda's concept of the video game sensorium emphasizes that a game's meaning is shaped through the full sensory experience—including mechanics, aesthetics, and interaction. *Open* leans into this principle through the strategic placement of objects and the spatial design of

rooms, evoking a sense of claustrophobia and dread without relying on jump scares, voiceover narration, or explicit backstory. For example, the room where Ed is locked up is noticeably smaller than any of the bedrooms. It contains only a small twin-sized bed, with no decorations or entertainment—unlike Wally’s or Minty’s rooms, which each feature larger beds and personalized furniture. There is also a completely empty room that mirrors the absence of the mother. The storage room is so overfilled that the player cannot even walk further inside, hinting that the family has not truly settled into this new home. The lingering disorganization suggests that, since the mother’s death, emotional bonds between family members have weakened—evidenced by the fact that no one has bothered to move the old sofa upstairs, likely because shared family time has diminished. The father’s room, though furnished with expensive items, feels cold and vacant, emphasizing his absence from the household and his preoccupation with work. In contrast, the objects in Minty’s and Wally’s rooms reflect their personalities and inner lives. Minty’s room contains soft, fluffy objects like stuffed animals and a plush carpet, which speak to her kind, gentle disposition and sympathetic attitude toward Ed. The family photo, firmly pinned to her wall, is described in-game as “impossible to take down”—a metaphor for her unwavering love and her desire to hold the family together. Wally’s room, on the other hand, reveals his struggle to appear strong and responsible. It contains workout equipment and files from his internship, signaling his attempt to become more like his father, whom he admires. His room also straddles a line between immaturity and aspiration—furnished partly with childlike wooden furniture, similar to Minty’s, and partly with more refined touches like a well-kept carpet. Color design also plays a critical role in reinforcing identity and emotion throughout *Open*. Each family member is associated with a distinctive color palette that informs their bedroom design, clothing, and even narrative hints, especially regarding the player’s

identity. For instance, Wally's bed features a black and blue patterned sheet, where blue represents Wally's theme and black symbolizes the father. These color cues subtly communicate relational dynamics and hierarchy within the family.

Environmental storytelling deepens the emotional resonance and reinforces key themes such as isolation and control. In Minty's room, for example, a trash can contains scratch paper filled with math problems and a small sketch of the entire family—"all five of us... It was." This quiet moment conveys a sense of loss without directly stating it. In Wally's room, a police letter buried beneath work files reveals that, half a year ago, authorities were still trying to locate Ed and instructed the family to report his whereabouts. That the letter remains buried suggests Wally's conscious decision to hide Ed. These small details not only build tension and mystery but also encourage the player to reflect on what is left unsaid. As they move through the house, the player is not only exploring physical space but also navigating emotional terrain.

Conclusion: Why Open Matters

In the end, Open is not just a title. It is a declaration of its design philosophy: a narrative that invites interpretation, a structure that welcomes player freedom, and a world that unfolds through emotional systems and environmental clues rather than exposition. Its uniqueness lies in how it deceives and guides the player simultaneously, encouraging them to open every door—literal and metaphorical—in order to confront not only the game's story, but their own assumptions and emotional responses along the way.

Works Cited

Clune, Michael W. *Gameline*. Farrar, Straus and Giroux, 2015.

Jagoda, Patrick. *Experimental Games: Critique, Play, and Design in the Age of Gamification*.

University of Chicago Press, 2020.

Juul, Jesper. *The Art of Failure: An Essay on the Pain of Playing Video Games*. MIT Press, 2013.

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doi:10.1093/oso/9780190052089.003.0001.

Supplementary Materials



Image 1: Drawings from the Escape Ending animation (without entering Ed's Room) that depict flashbacks of Minty's death and hint at the hidden story.

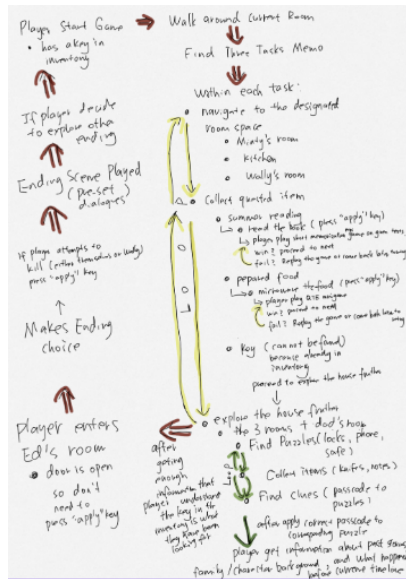


Image 2: Screenshot of the game loop design.



Image 3: First Sketch of the family photo.

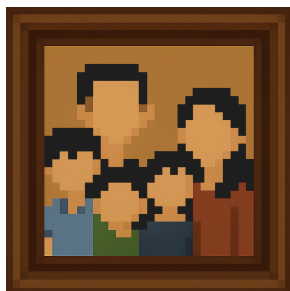


Image 4: Final version of the family photo in 2D pixel art. Each family member has a unique associated color.



Image 5: Dad's Room



Image 6: Minty's Room



Image 7: Ed's Room



Image 8: Wally's Room